processing societies 'will be for the definite purpose of adding to the resources hitherto available to the sectors of co-operative marketing and processing societies', and that 'the need for such supplementing of resources arises particularly in States where the co-operative banking structure is weak and unable to meet the needs of agricultural production credit as well as marketing credit adequately'.[12]

In keeping with this view, the bank financed marketing and processing co-operative societies wherever necessary, and also extended remittance facilities and short-term accommodation to the co-operative central financing institutions to stimulate and assist them in their operations. With the passage of time, it extended the scope of its assistance to a wider field, namely, co-operative sugar factories, co-operative spinning mills, industrial cooperatives, wholesale consumer stores, etc. The bank's outstanding assistance to co-operatives of all categories amounted to about ₹41.04 crores at the end of March 1968. Besides these advances, the bank had also been giving the co-operatives a place in its investment portfolio by extending support to the debenture issues of co-operative central land mortgage banks. Its holdings of such debentures increased from ₹5 lakhs in 1955 to ₹20.35 crores in March 1968.[13] At the end of 1967, co-operative institutions of all types (excluding co-operative societies of the bank's staff), had been granted limits aggregating ₹61.7 cores. By the end of March 1966, the SBI accounted for as much as 79.8 percent of the total advances of all scheduled commercial banks to co-operatives. Along with the subsidiaries, the public sector banks' percentage stood at 89.3.[14]

SMALL-SCALE INDUSTRIES

Considering the important role played by small-scale industries in the generation of employment and in bringing about balanced regional growth and diffusion of economic power, the SBI had made systematic efforts from the beginning to foster the development of small-scale industries in active collaboration with other specialized institutional agencies set up for the purpose. The bank liberalized several of its procedures and in some cases also tailored the banking services to the needs of small industries rather than insisting on a rigid adherence to rules and regulations. The number of small-scale industrial units assisted by the bank increased from twenty-five